Estimations of economic power are many, and an India–China comparison could fill an entire book. Here we confine ourselves to an overall comparison of economic vitality (GDP, financial reserves, technological innovation, and market leadership), infrastructure and energy, and quality of population in terms of productivity.

Economic Vitality

According to World Bank figures, in 1962, the year that India and China fought, India's GDP (in current US dollars) was $42 billion. China's GDP was $47 billion. The gap was a mere $5 billion – virtually nothing. In 2019, India's GDP was $2.875 trillion, and China's was $14.343 trillion. The GDP gap was $11.468 trillion (it is over $14 trillion if you go by purchasing power parity figures). From a position of rough equality in 1962, India's economy is now one-fifth of China's, and India's per capita GDP is one-fourth of China's.

Between 1962 and 2019, there is not a single year when India equalled China's GDP. In terms of GDP growth rates, in the fifty-six years between 1961 and 2019, India surpassed China only thirteen times, despite the fact that from 1949 to 1980 China's was a centralized, communist economy and India's was a mixed economy with a robust private sector. The economic historian Angus Maddison's 2010 data set shows that the last time India beat China in overall GDP terms was in 1700 – when the Mughals were at their peak.[2]

A country's total reserves (for example, hard currency, gold) is another indicator of economic strength. In 1980, India's total reserves are estimated to have been $12.01 billion. China was just embarking on its economic reforms in that year and had $10.09 billion. The gap was in India's favour by $2 billion. The figures today are astonishingly different for both countries, and the gap is massively in China's favour. In 2019, India's total reserves were estimated at $463.47 billion while China's were $3.222